

# Technical Insights: Essential Skills for IAM Architects

Nat Krishnan

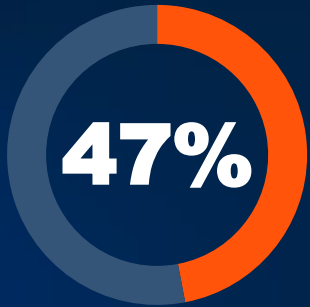
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# Skilled IAM Architects Are **Still** to Find

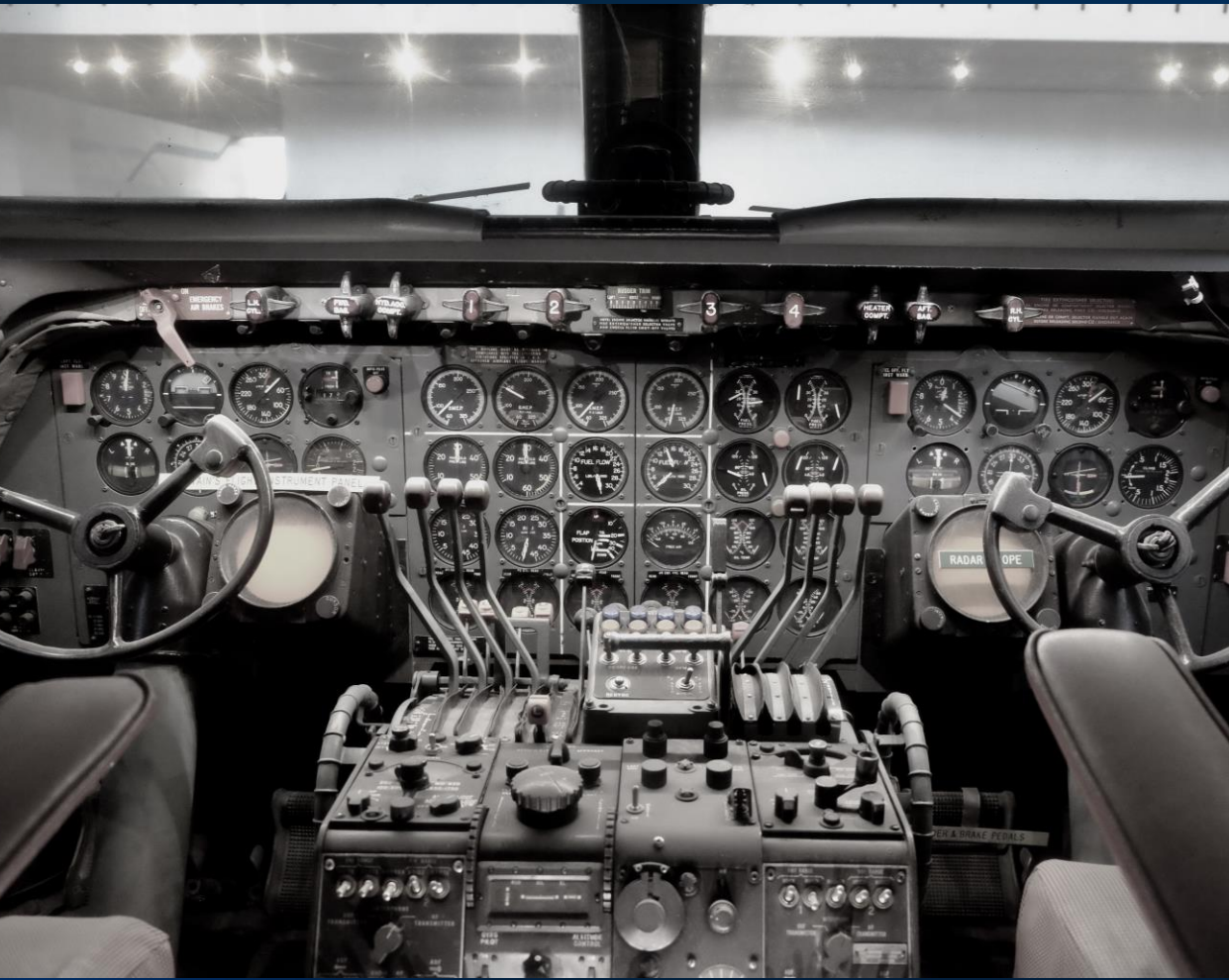


**Most** organizations plan to increase their investment in core IAM capabilities.



of teams are not adequately staffed for IAM projects.

# Old Skills With New Tech? It Doesn't End Well.



1

**Essential  
skills framework  
for IAM**

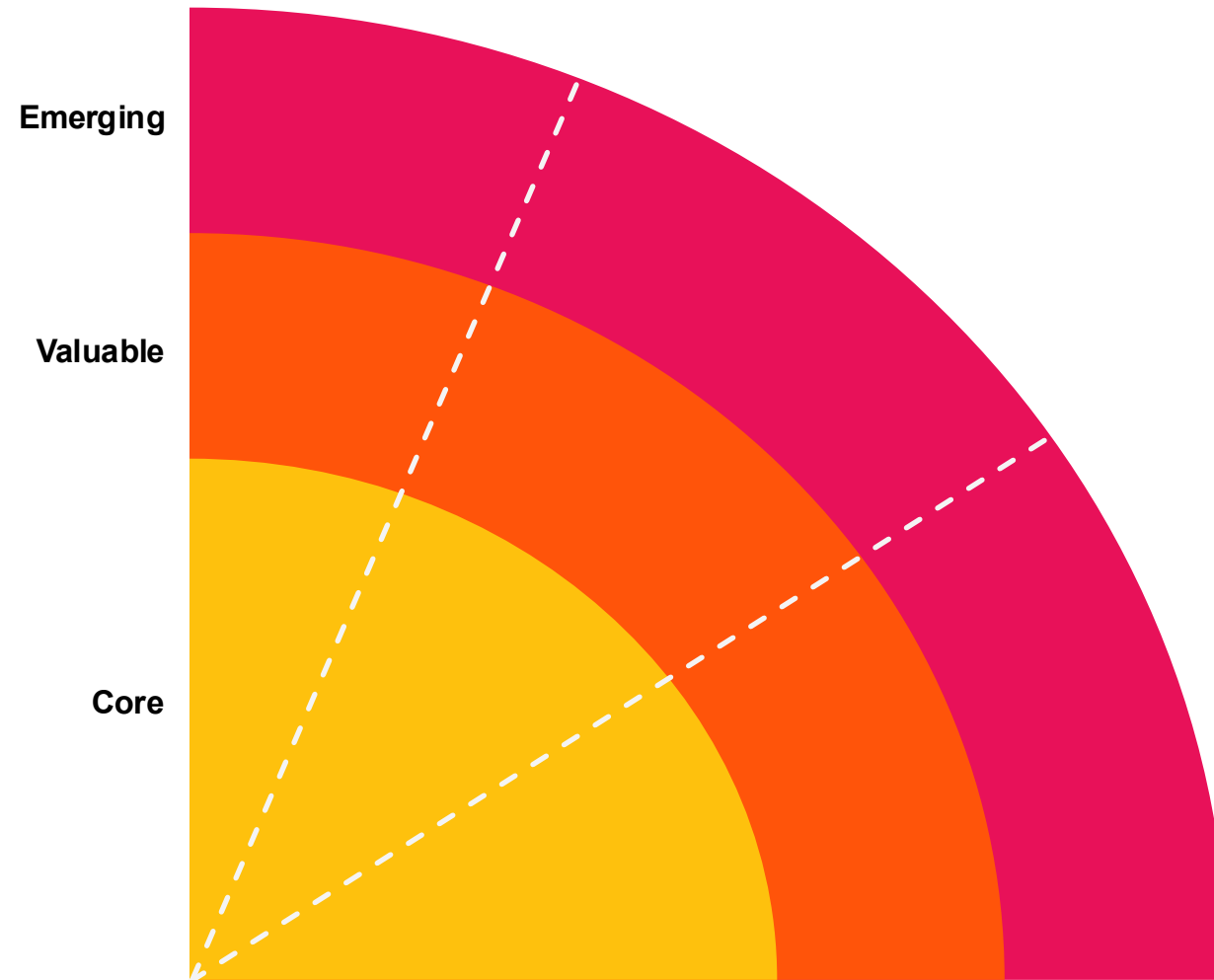
2

**Core skills**

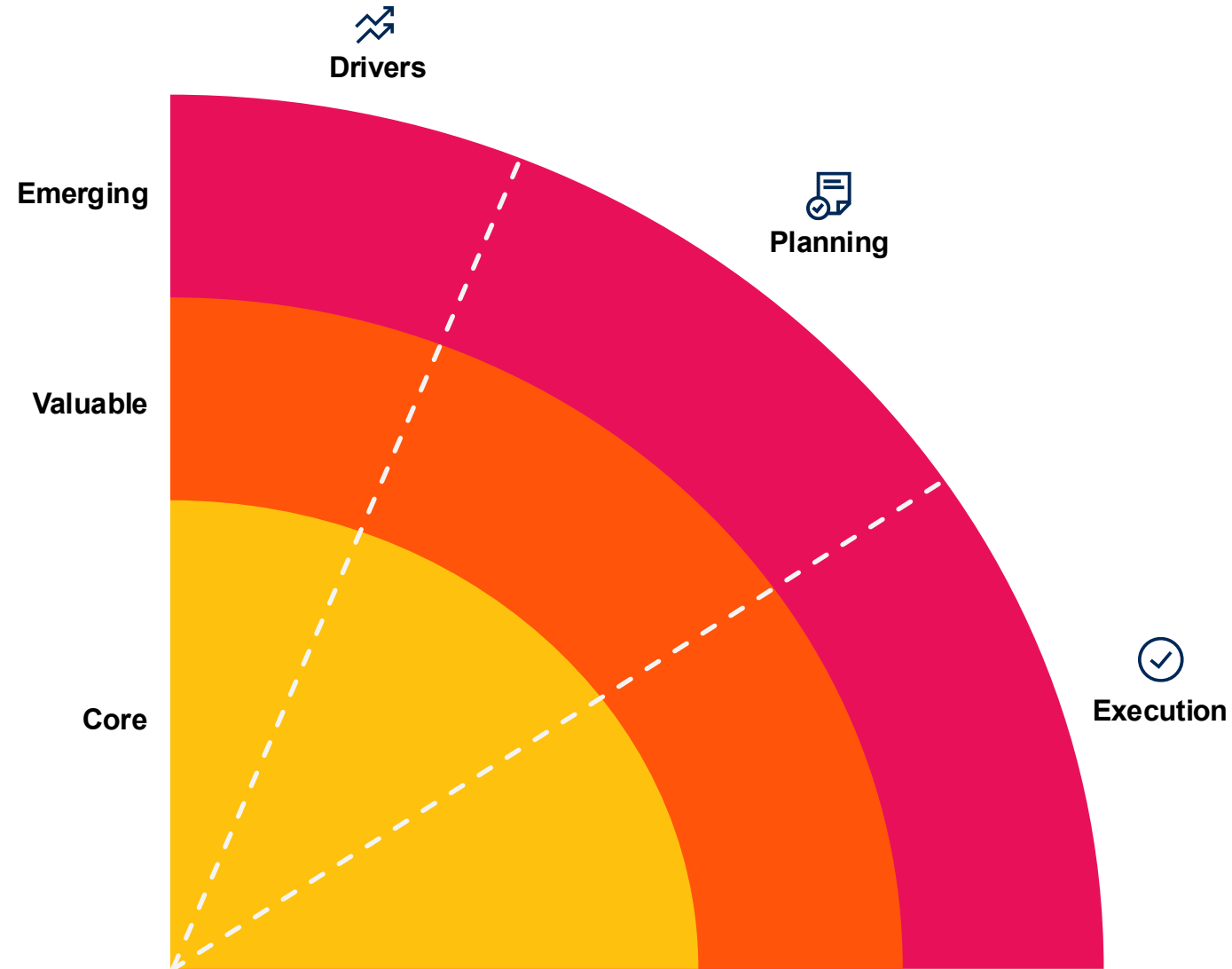
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**Valuable skills,  
emerging skills and  
other knowledge**

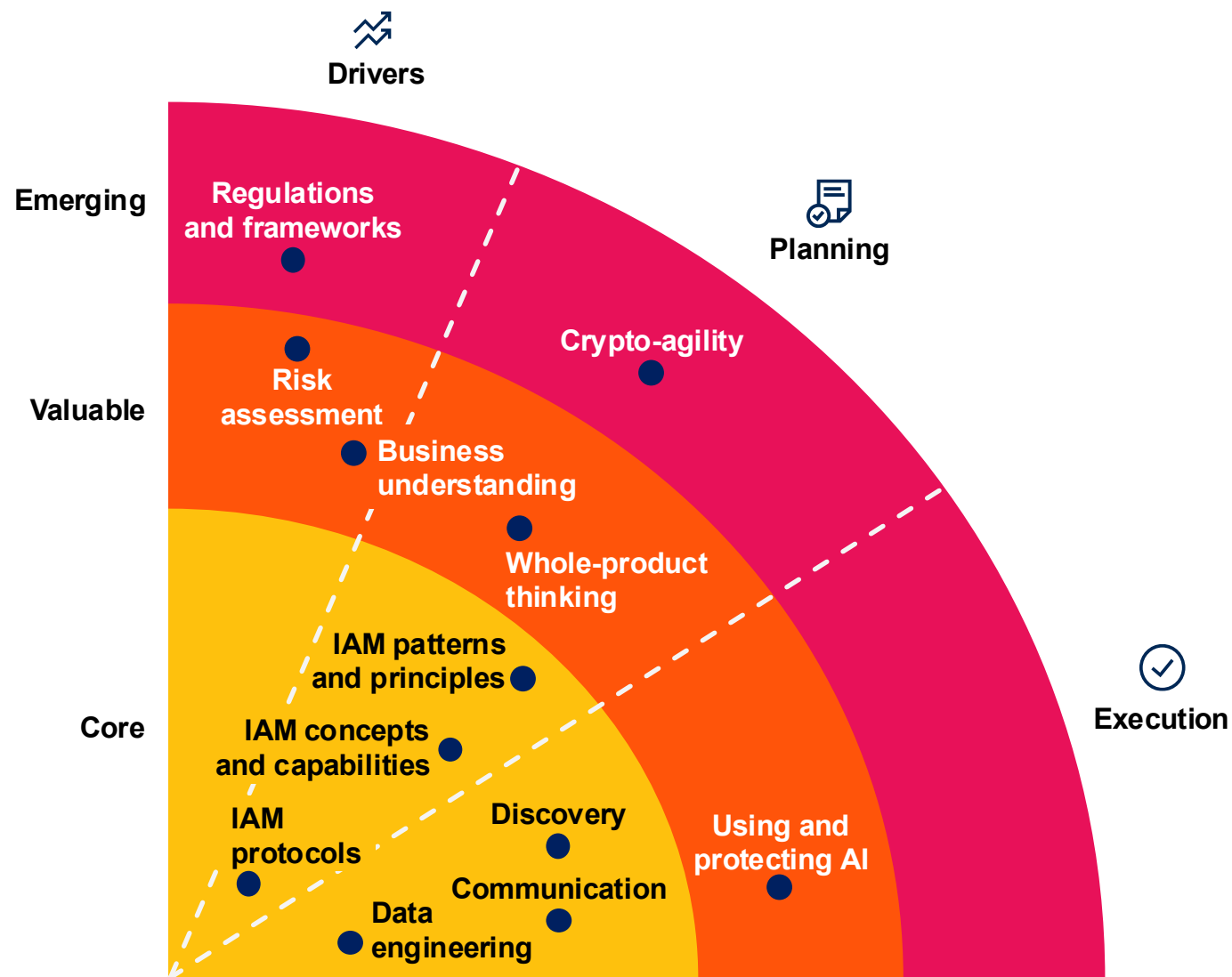
# Essential Skills — Relevance



# Categories



# Categories



1

Essential  
skills framework  
for IAM

2

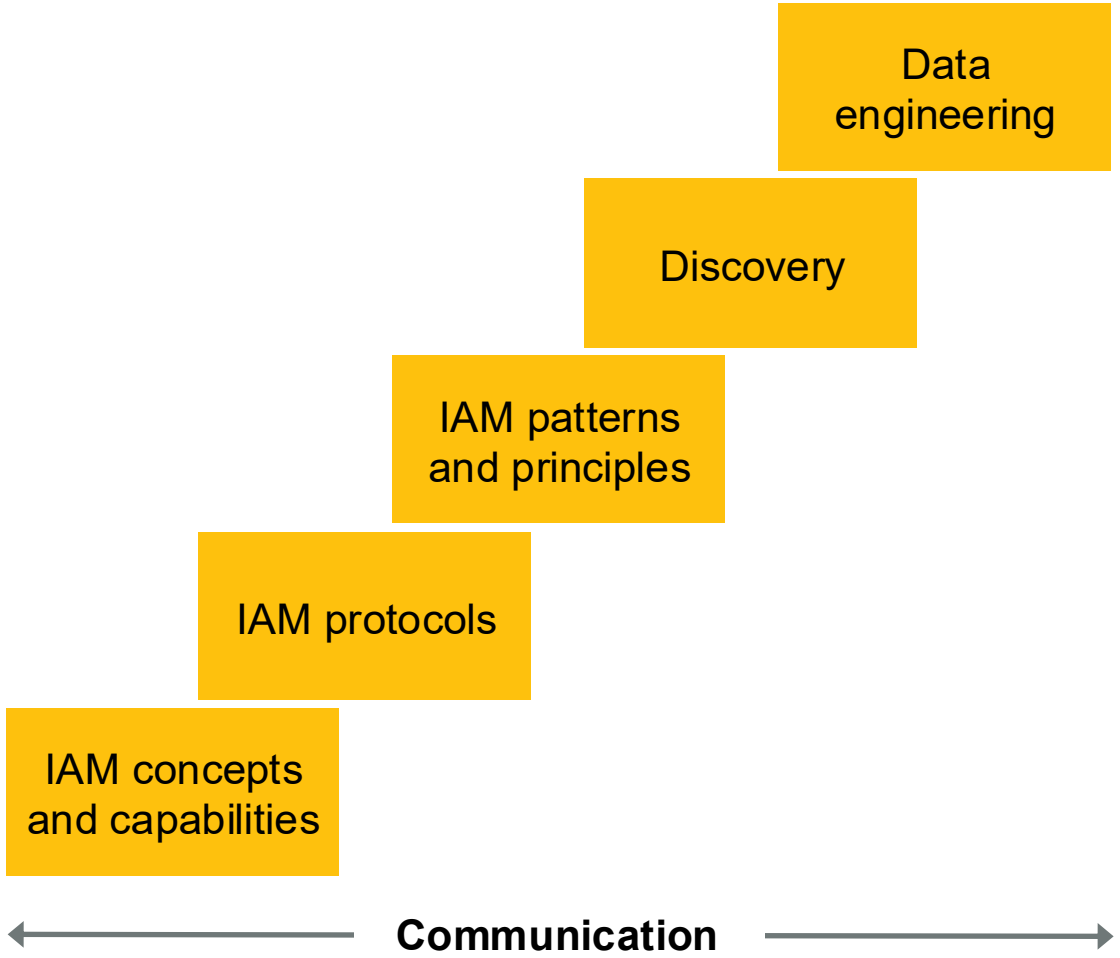
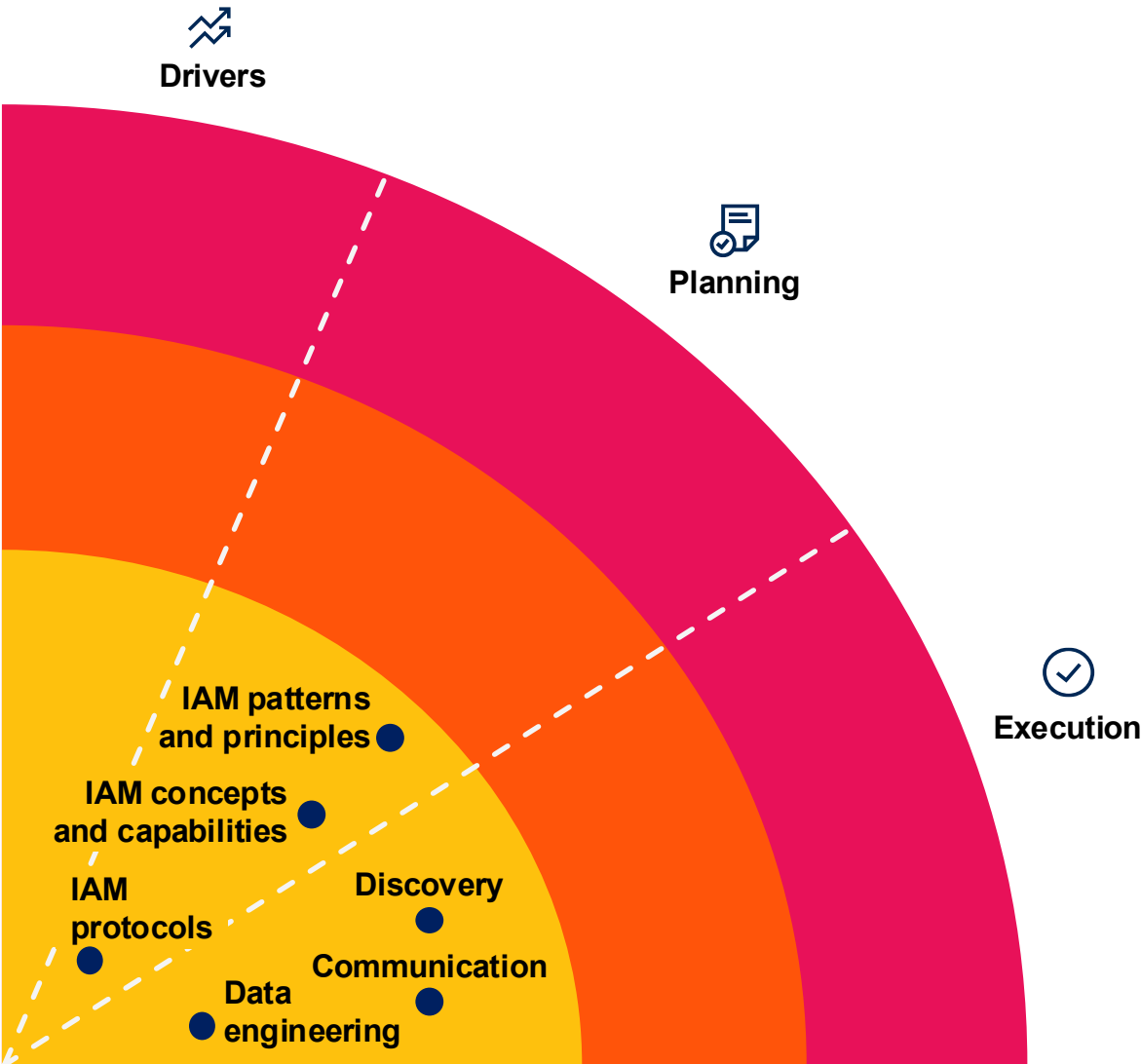
**Core skills**

3

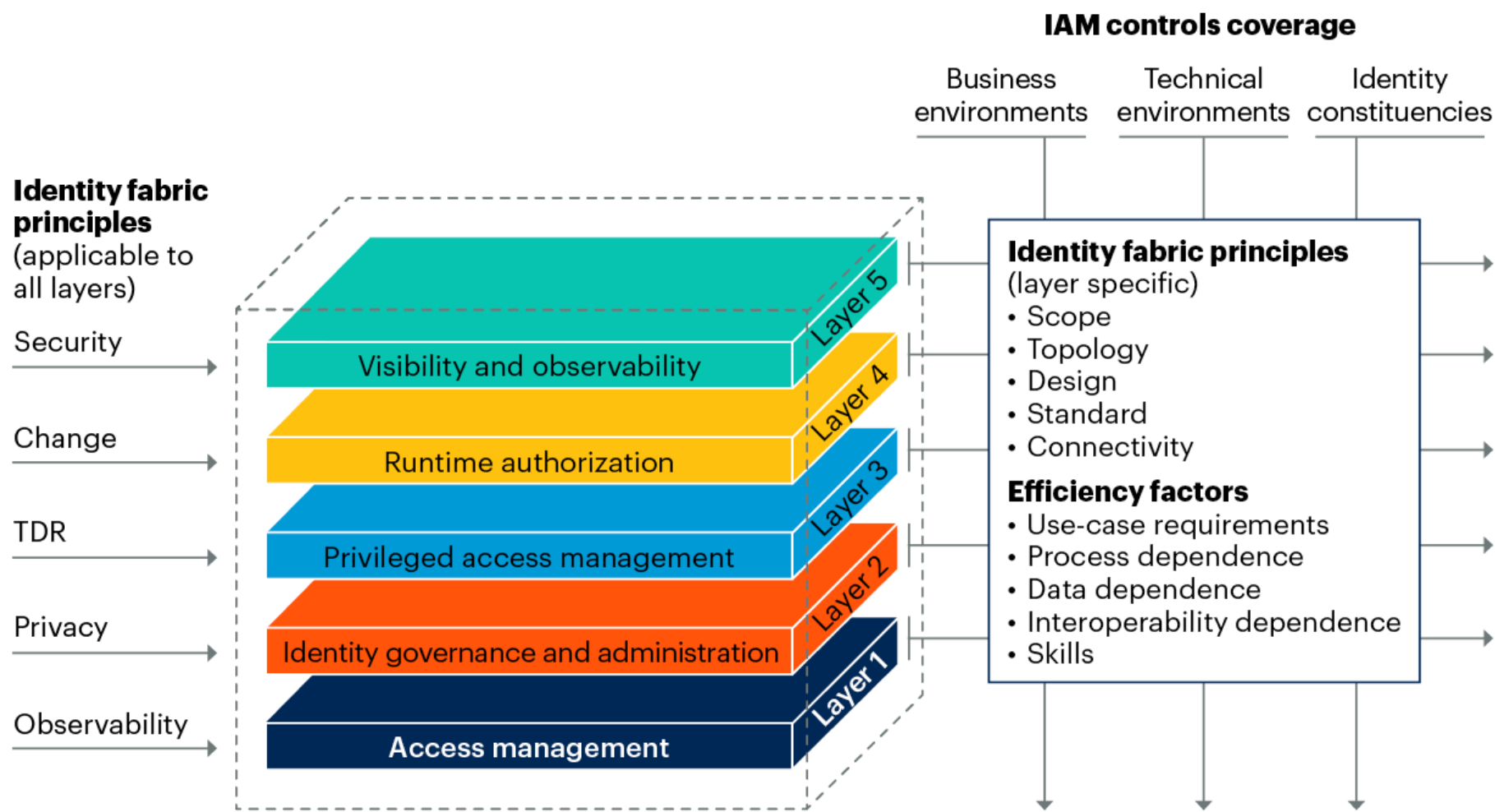
Valuable skills,  
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# Core Skills



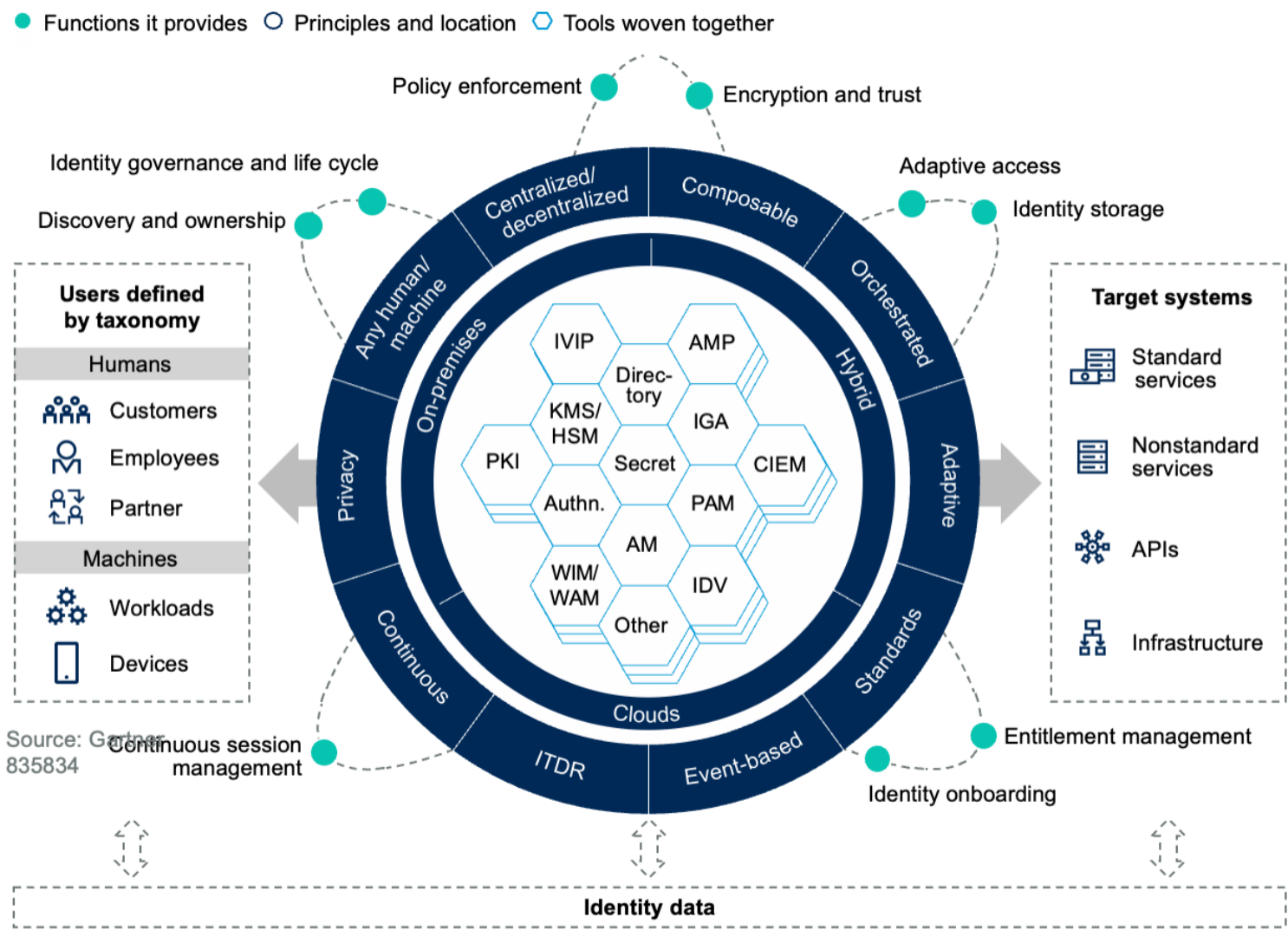
# IAM Concepts and Capabilities



# IAM Protocols



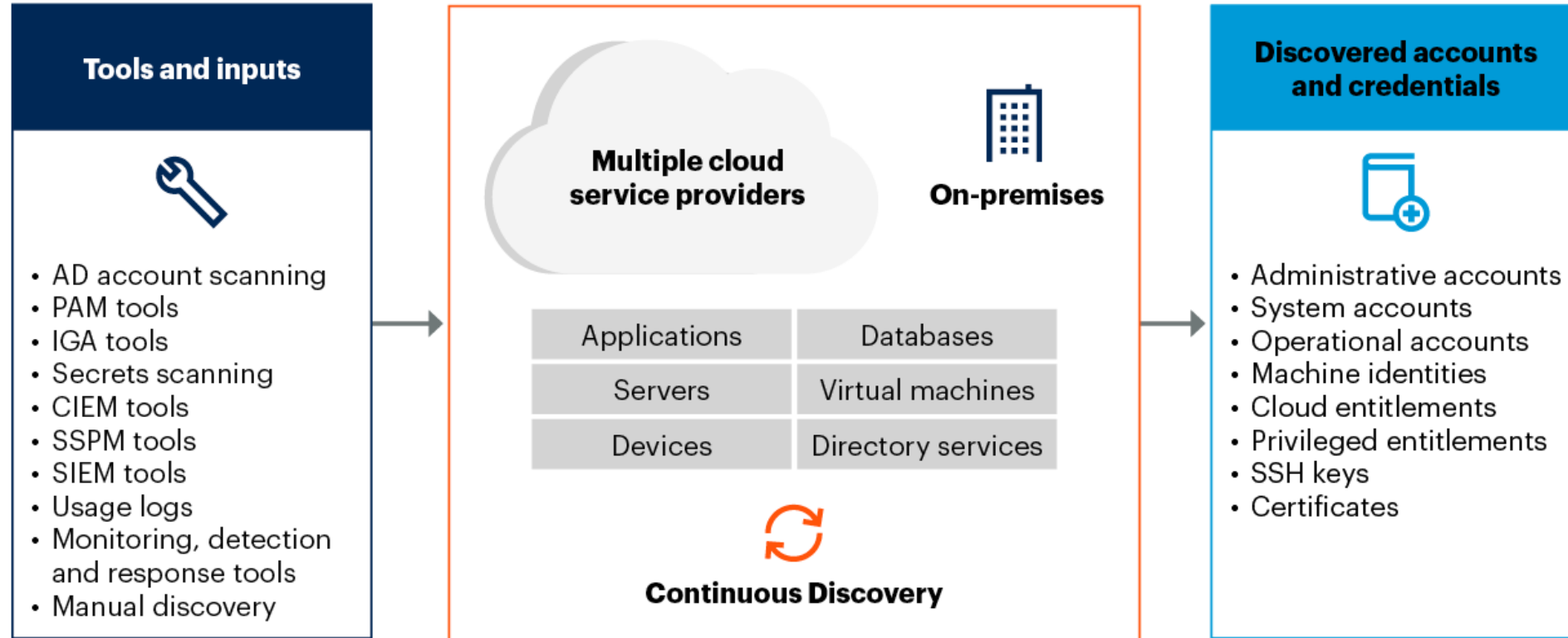
# IAM Patterns and Principles



# Discovery for Identity and Access Data



## Continuous Discovery in Action



# Data Engineering



## Core Identity and Access Data

Human Identity  
(workforce, partners,  
customers/consumers)

Machine Identity  
(workloads and devices)

Organization  
Information

Resources  
(apps,  
infrastructure,  
data stores, etc.)

Accounts  
(including authentication  
credentials)

Entitlements  
(permissions)

Access Policies  
(binds all others together)

Access Events



## Other High Value (for IAM) Data

Project/Product Team  
(work assignment)

IT Service Tickets

Product and Service Relationships  
(which products a customer  
has purchased)

Work Relationships  
(e.g., care provider to  
patient and account team  
to client organization)

Training Records

# Mastering Communication

- Master inbound and outbound communication
- Explain and get acceptance for what's being delivered
- Articulate the business case of IAM
- Facilitate inbound communication



1

**Essential  
skills framework  
for IAM**

2

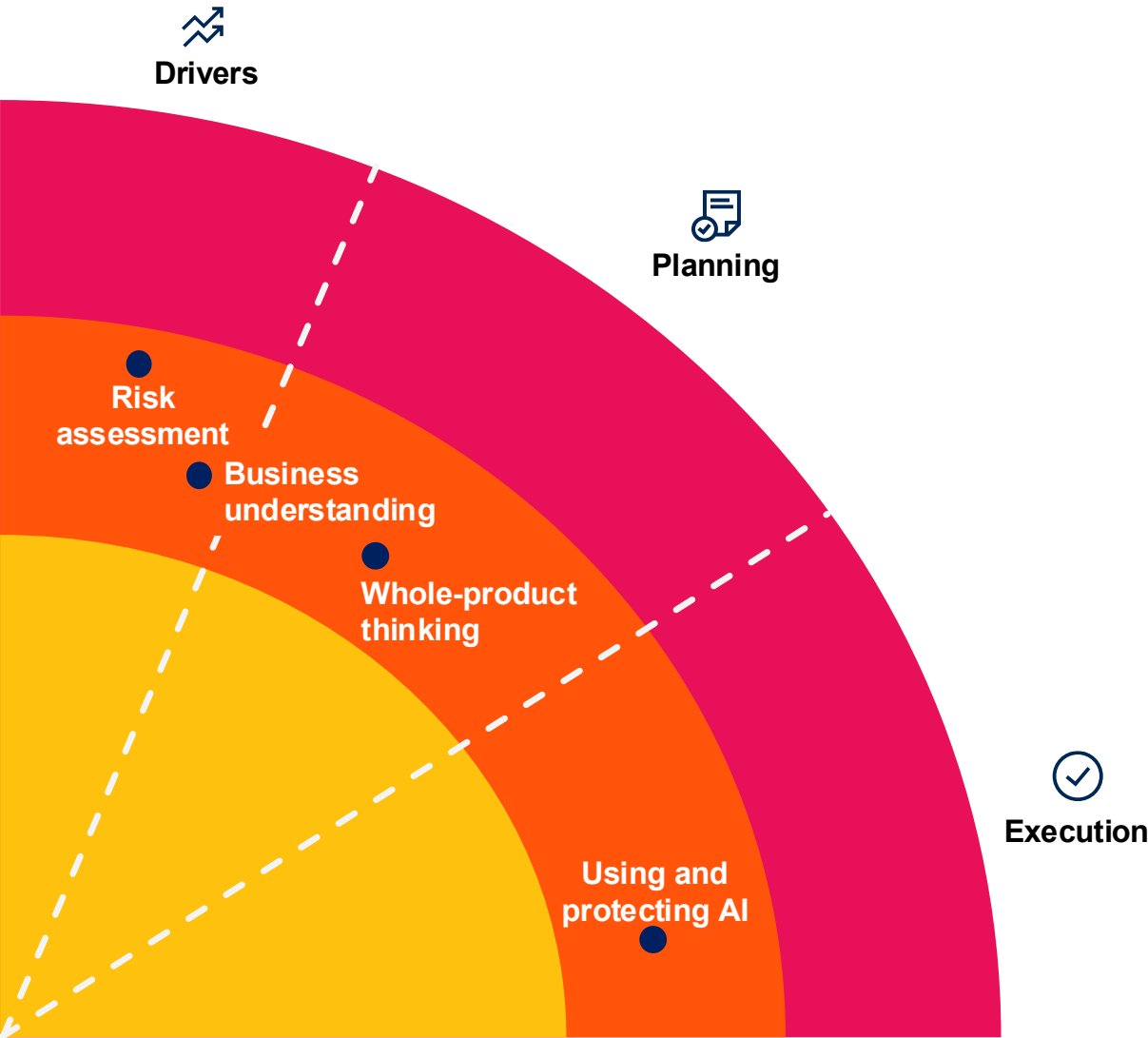
**Core skills**

3

**Valuable skills,  
emerging skills and  
other knowledge**



# Valuable Skills



|                        |                         |
|------------------------|-------------------------|
| Risk assessment        | Business understanding  |
| Whole-product thinking | Using and protecting AI |

# Business Understanding

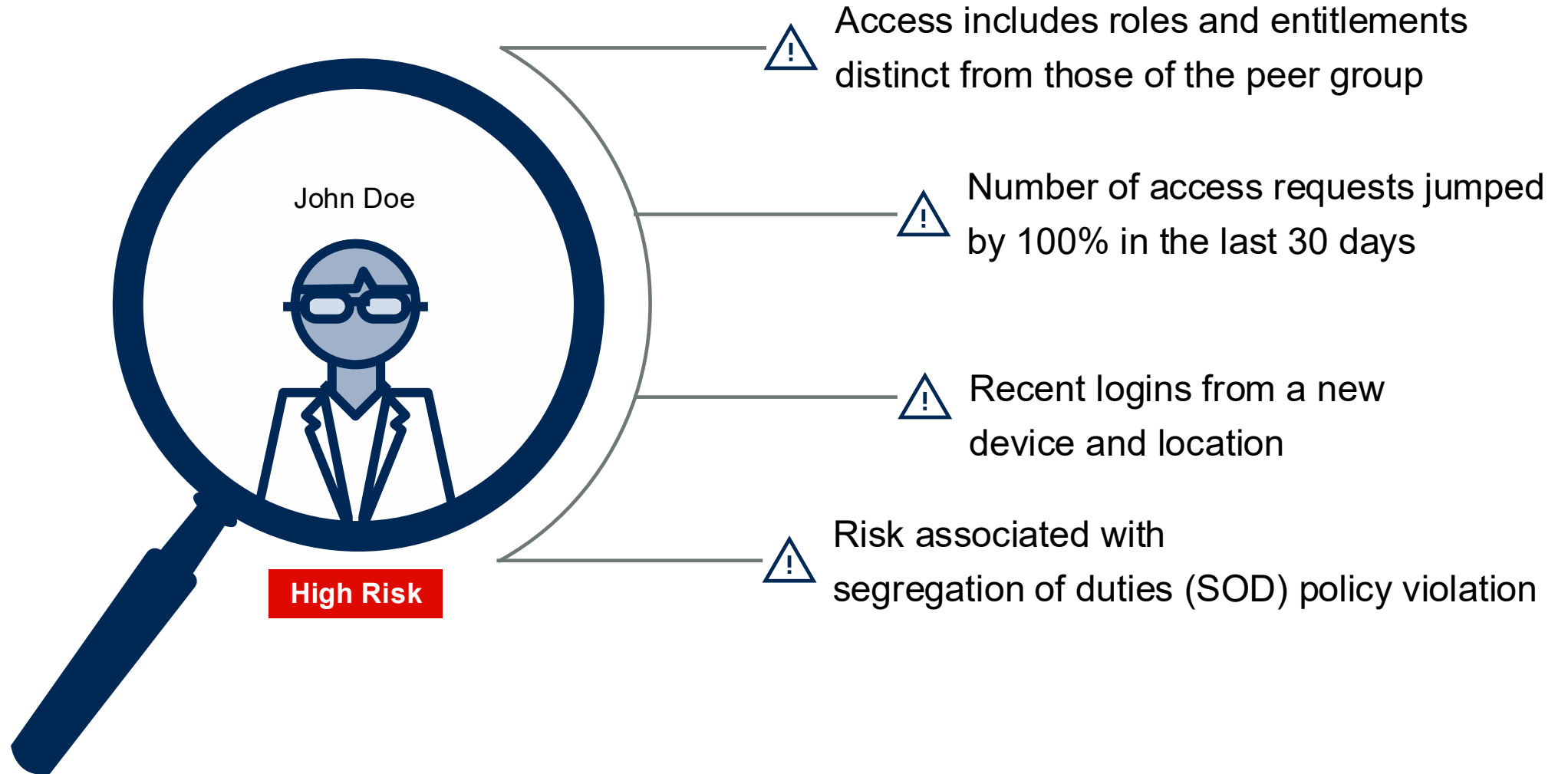


# Whole-Product Thinking



- Apply whole-product analysis by evaluating IAM's role in a customer's context
- Prioritize IAM from a customer's perspective (security/compliance/business enablement)
- Technology thinking → Product thinking
- Address user experience challenges

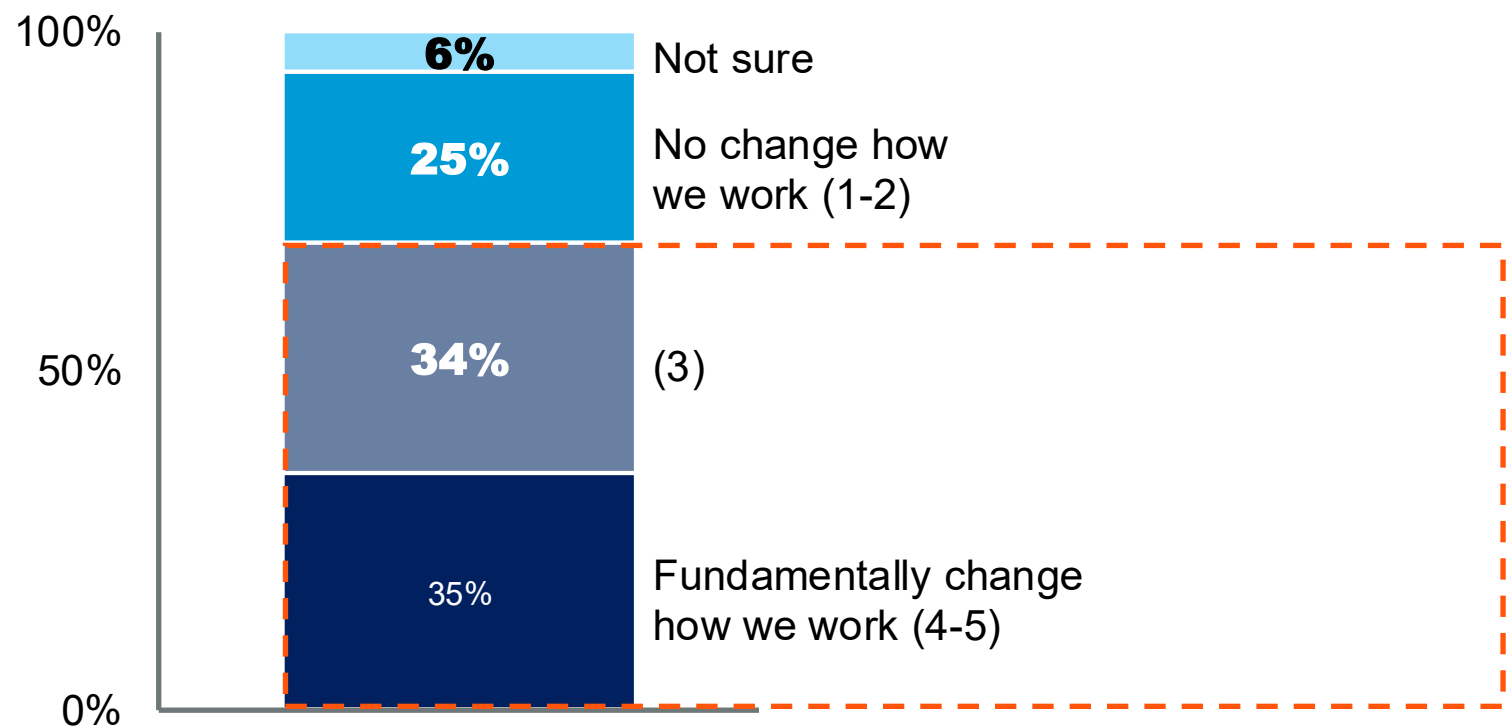
# Risk Assessment



# Impact of GenAI

## Impact of generative AI on how organizations work

5-point scale from no change to fundamentally change



n = 91 IT leaders

Q01: In the next year, what impact do you think generative AI will have on how your organization works? 5-point scale.

Source: 2023 Gartner IT Leader Poll on Generative AI for Software Engineering

# Using and Protecting AI

## Key Generative AI Impacts on IAM



### Enhancements



#### Identity-First Security

- Provides more consistent, contextual and continuous IAM controls



#### Identity Fabric Functions

- Reduces manual processes and improving identity data



#### Coverage and Error Reduction

- Adds intelligent IAM co-pilot and automation agents

### Challenges



#### Trustworthiness and Ethical Issues

- Maintaining trust by model integrity and neutrality



#### Reality Alteration and Privacy Threats

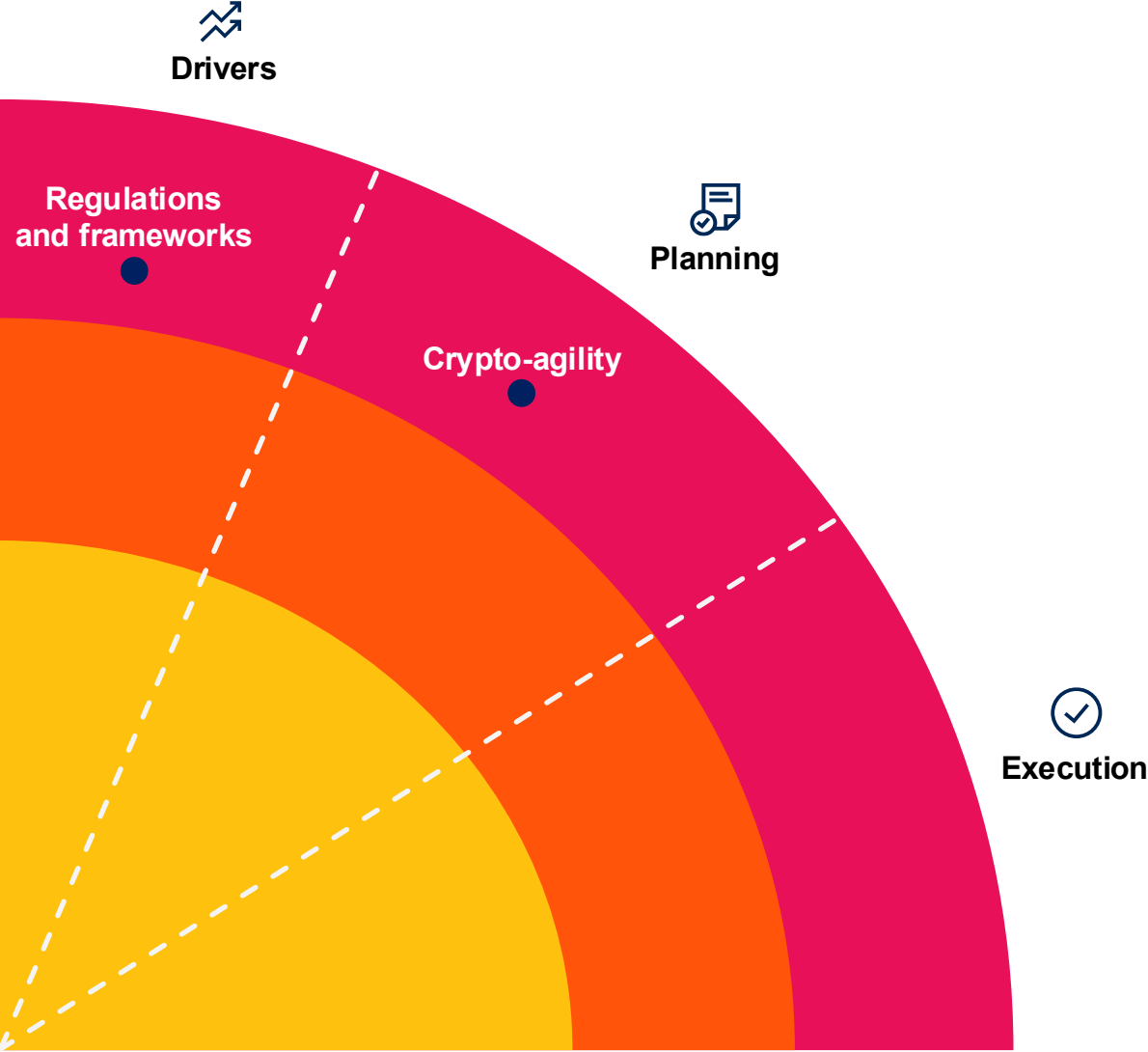
- Controlling access to private data by fake identities



#### Security and Adversarial Attack at Scale

- Preventing manipulation by fake identities and data

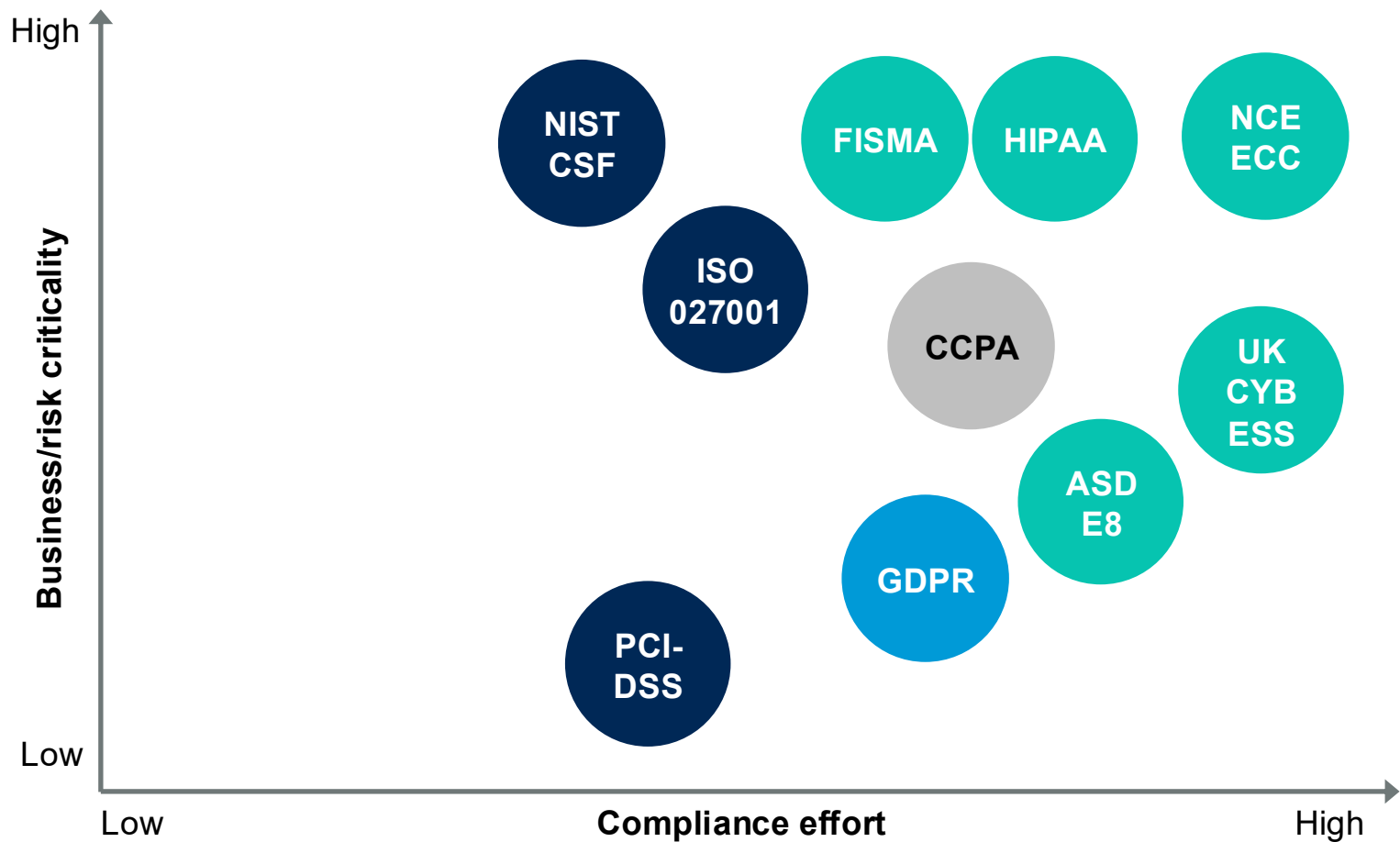
# Emerging Skills



# Regulations and Security Frameworks



● Local/state level    ● National level    ● International level    ● Industry specific



Source: [Tool: Template for Board Briefing on Cybersecurity Compliance](#)



# Establishing Crypto-Agility



**Gartner predicts that, by 2029, advances in quantum computing will make conventional asymmetric (public key) cryptography unsafe.**

- Technologies rely on public key cryptography
- Tools need plans for
  - Decommissioning
  - Upgrades or
  - Migration strategies

# Recommendations

- ④ Secure core IAM skills proficiencies first, to improve security, increase efficiency and enable business.
- ④ Keep up with identity standards, protocols and principles.
- ④ Adopt a continuous learning mindset to expedite upskilling.
- ④ Invest in communication skills to expand the sphere of influence.
- ④ Prioritize specialized and emerging patterns and technologies relevant to IAM.

# Gartner Recommended Research

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- 🔍 [Essential Skills for Identity Architects](#)  
Nat Krishnan
- 🔍 [Guidance for Comprehensive IAM Architecture Strategy](#)  
Homan Farahmand
- 🔍 [IAM — Taxonomy, Domains and Tooling](#)  
Erik Wahlstrom
- 🔍 [2026 Planning Guide for Identity and Access Management](#)  
Erik Wahlstrom, Mary Ruddy and Others
- 🔍 [Use IAM Architecture to Deliver Business Outcomes](#)  
Nathan Harris

Access to Gartner research is subject to individual subscription type and product entitlements.